

Apple iPhone

If you are bored with Symbian, you can try your hands on iPhone, a product of Apple. The software that it employs is known as the iPhone OS, which is closed source, although it is possible to have open source components installed in it.

The latest version of iPhone OS is v 3.0.1, which was released in August, 2009. Developed by Apple Inc., the iPhone OS has a default UI, which is Coca Touch. The licence that it follows is EULA (except for open source components). The software platform that it supports are ARMv6 and ARMv7-A.

The free iPhone OS 3.0 update comprises some great new features, in addition to all the features from the previous updates. iPhone OS 3.0 lets you run the next generation of iPhone applications like peer-to-peer games. It is easy to cut, copy and paste text from application to application. Moreover, you can copy images from the Web, too. In this update of OS, you have a landscape keyboard layout option. You can rotate your iPhone to use a larger keyboard for mailing, messaging, etc.

An interesting feature to look out for in the iPhone is spotlight search, through which you can search all your contacts, e-mails, calendars and notes. You can download movies, TV shows, music videos and audiobooks from the iTunes Store on your iPhone. The latest version of the iPhone supports 30 languages and more than 40 keyboard layouts.

Windows

The most preferred and the most dominating one in last few years has been the Windows OS, a proprietary software, and the latest stable version it proffers is v6.5. Developed by Microsoft, it is distributed under the licence EULA.

The latest version has improved core applications like Contact Manager. You can easily access or search any contact just by tapping the key-

board 2-3 times. Other improvements are in Calendar, Contacts and Notes. Moreover, the office files have been made compatible with the desktop, so that you no longer need to change the file formats when transferring files from the mobile to the desktop and vice versa.

Certain other features that you can notice are the two ways in which you can unlock the device, either by sliding the button or by tapping on screen. The main screen also exhibits your next appointment and has icons, using which you can browse through your pictures and view the calendar.

In order to browse through the menu, you need to press the start button. The start button takes you to the newly designed menu list. The menu list in this mobile OS cannot be customised as per users' wishes, unlike in the iPhone. In Windows, you have to scroll through the list to find the icons but you can move the menu icons and keep the most used icons at the top.

Another feature that has been bettered is the scrolling feature. When you hit the end while scrolling, the menu bounces back and you have the option to scroll it more swiftly. In order to stop it, all you need to do is tap on the screen.

The next version of Windows mobile OS will be Windows Mobile 7, which is expected to be released in 2010.

Blackberry

The BlackBerry OS is a proprietary software, whose latest stable version is 4.7.0.172. The creators of the OS are Research In Motion. This version supports many languages. BlackBerry OS enables multi-tasking and makes heavy use of input devices like the track ball. The OS also has support for MIDP 1.0 and WAP 1.2.

BlackBerry OS can be synchronised with your PC, as swapping data from one to the other is very

simple. It supports three office applications—Excel, Power Point and Word—but there are some limitations involved with the viewing of certain documents.

The latest but unstable v 5.0 of BlackBerry has quite a few improvements but a few glitches as well. The icons and the layout of the main screen remains the same but there are certain features, which have been eliminated. The facebook integration with BlackBerry OS has been removed and there is no way of installing it either. However, it does have a new feature, with which you can play music tracks directly without entering into any media application.

Being an unstable version, there are a few flaws that you may find in BlackBerry 5.0, but once the stable version is out, a lot of these drawbacks will be taken care of.

Right choice

By now you must have had a general overview of the existing OS going the rounds currently, and what each one has to offer. But you must be now more confused about which one to choose from, or which one suits you the most.

The best way to decide which OS is best for you is to figure out its features. When buying a mobile phone, we consider the cosmetic factors, but the chief criteria for the selection of a mobile phone should actually be the OS. In low-priced mobile phones, you will find the most basic OS features like music player, messaging, camera interfaces, MMS facilities, etc. However, the higher-end mobile phones with BlackBerry or Windows OS tend to offer more advanced features.

So, the next time you are contemplating purchasing a mobile phone, don't just go for its looks and the price, pay close attention to the OS as well, as that is what makes the phone worthy. ●

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